

The turbine has the capability of producing manifold pressure in excess of the maximum allowable for the particular engine. In order not to exceed the maximum allowable manifold pressure, a bypass or waste gate is used so that some of the exhaust is diverted overboard before it passes through the turbine.

The position of the waste gate regulates the output of the turbine and therefore, the compressed air available to the engine. When the waste gate is closed, all of the exhaust gases pass through and drive the turbine. As the waste gate opens, some of the exhaust gases are routed around the turbine through the exhaust bypass and overboard through the exhaust pipe.

The waste gate actuator is a spring-loaded piston operated by engine oil pressure. The actuator, which adjusts the waste gate position, is connected to the waste gate by a mechanical linkage.

The control center of the turbocharger system is the pressure controller. This device simplifies turbocharging to one control: the throttle. Once the desired manifold pressure is set, virtually no throttle adjustment is required with changes in altitude. The controller senses compressor discharge requirements for various altitudes and controls the oil pressure to the waste gate actuator, which adjusts the waste gate accordingly. Thus the turbocharger will maintain the manifold pressure called for by the throttle setting.

Ground Boosting Versus Altitude Turbocharging

Altitude turbocharging (sometimes called “normalizing”) is accomplished by using a turbocharger that maintains maximum allowable sea level manifold pressure (normally 29–30 "Hg) up to a certain altitude. This altitude is specified by the airplane manufacturer and is referred to as the airplane’s critical altitude. Above the critical altitude, the manifold pressure decreases as additional altitude is gained. Ground boosting, on the other hand, is an application of turbocharging where more than the standard 29 inches of manifold pressure is used in flight. In various airplanes using ground boosting, takeoff manifold pressures may go as high as 45 "Hg.

Although a sea-level manifold pressure setting and maximum rpm can be maintained up to the critical altitude, the engine may not be developing sea-level power. Because the turbocharged induction air is heated by compression, lower induction air density causes a loss of engine power. Maintaining the equivalent horsepower output requires a somewhat higher manifold pressure at a given altitude than if the induction air were not compressed and heated by turbocharging. If, on the other hand, the system incorporates an automatic density controller, which automatically positions the waste gate so as to maintain constant air density to the engine, a near equivalent to sea-level horsepower output results.

Operating Characteristics

First and foremost, all movements of the power controls on turbocharged engines should be slow and smooth. Aggressive or abrupt throttle movements increase the possibility of over-boosting. Carefully monitor engine indications when making power changes.

When the waste gate is open, the turbocharged engine reacts the same as a normally aspirated engine when the rpm is varied. That is, when the rpm is increased, the manifold pressure decreases slightly. When the engine rpm is decreased, the manifold pressure increases slightly. However, when the waste gate is closed, manifold pressure variation with engine rpm is just the opposite of the normally aspirated engine. An increase in engine rpm results in an increase in manifold pressure, and a decrease in engine rpm results in a decrease in manifold pressure.

Above the critical altitude, where the waste gate is closed, any change in airspeed results in a corresponding change in manifold pressure. This is true because the increase in ram air pressure with an increase in airspeed is magnified by the compressor resulting in an increase in manifold pressure. The increase in manifold pressure creates a higher mass flow through the engine, causing higher turbine speeds and thus further increasing manifold pressure.

When running at high altitudes, aviation gasoline tends to vaporize prior to reaching the cylinder. If this occurs in the portion of the fuel system between the fuel tank and the engine-driven fuel pump, an auxiliary positive pressure pump may be needed in the tank. Since engine-driven pumps pull fuel, they are easily vapor locked. A boost pump provides positive pressure, which pushes the fuel and reduces the tendency to vaporize.

Heat Management

Turbocharged engines should be thoughtfully and carefully operated with continuous monitoring of pressures and temperatures. There are two temperatures that are especially important—turbine inlet temperature (TIT) or, in some installations, exhaust gas temperature (EGT) and cylinder head temperature. TIT or EGT limits are set to protect the elements in the hot section of the turbocharger, while cylinder head temperature limits protect the engine’s internal parts.

Due to the heat of compression of the induction air, a turbocharged engine runs at higher operating temperatures than a non-turbocharged engine. Because turbocharged engines operate at high altitudes, their environment is less efficient for cooling. At altitude, the air is less dense and, therefore, cools less efficiently. Also, the less dense air causes the compressor to work harder. Compressor turbine speeds can reach 80,000–100,000 rpm, adding to the overall engine operating temperatures. Turbocharged engines are also operated at higher power settings a greater portion of the time.

High heat is detrimental to piston engine operation. Its cumulative effects can lead to piston, ring, and cylinder head failure and place thermal stress on other operating components. Excessive cylinder head temperature can lead to detonation, which in turn can cause catastrophic engine failure. Turbocharged engines are especially heat sensitive. The key to turbocharger operation is effective heat management.

Monitor the condition of a turbocharged engine with manifold pressure gauge, tachometer, exhaust gas temperature/turbine inlet temperature gauge, and cylinder head temperature gauge. Manage the “heat system” with the throttle, propeller rpm, mixture, and cowl flaps. At any given cruise power, the mixture is the most influential control over the exhaust gas/TIT. The throttle regulates total fuel flow, but the mixture governs the fuel-to-air ratio. The mixture, therefore, controls temperature.

Exceeding temperature limits in an after-takeoff climb is usually not a problem since a full rich mixture cools with excess fuel. At cruise, power is normally reduced and mixture adjusted accordingly. Under cruise conditions, monitor temperature limits closely because that is when the temperatures are most likely to reach the maximum, even though the engine is producing less power. Overheating in an en route climb, however, may require fully open cowl flaps and a higher airspeed.

Since turbocharged engines operate hotter at altitude than normally aspirated engines, they are more prone to damage from cooling stress. Gradual reductions in power and careful monitoring of temperatures are essential in the descent phase. Extending the landing gear during the descent may help control the airspeed while maintaining a higher engine power setting. This allows the pilot to reduce power in small increments which allows the engine to cool slowly. It may also be necessary to lean the mixture slightly to eliminate roughness at the lower power settings.

Turbocharger Failure

Because of the high temperatures and pressures produced in the turbine exhaust system, any malfunction of the turbocharger should be treated with extreme caution. In all cases of turbocharger operation, the manufacturer’s recommended procedures should be followed. This is especially so in the case of turbocharger malfunction. However, in those instances where the manufacturer’s procedures do not adequately describe the actions to be taken in the event of a turbocharger failure, the following procedures should be used.

Over-Boost Condition

If an excessive rise in manifold pressure occurs during normal advancement of the throttle (possibly owing to faulty operation of the waste gate):

- Immediately retard the throttle smoothly to limit the manifold pressure below the maximum for the rpm and mixture setting.
- Operate the engine in such a manner as to avoid a further over-boost condition.

Low Manifold Pressure

Although this condition may be caused by a minor fault, it is quite possible that a serious exhaust leak has occurred creating a potentially hazardous situation:

- Shut down the engine in accordance with the recommended engine failure procedures, unless a greater emergency exists that warrants continued engine operation.
- If continuing to operate the engine, use the lowest power setting demanded by the situation and land as soon as practicable.

It is very important to ensure that corrective maintenance is undertaken following any turbocharger malfunction.

Retractable Landing Gear

The primary benefits of being able to retract the landing gear are increased climb performance and higher cruise airspeeds due to a decrease in drag after gear retraction. Retractable landing gear systems may be operated either hydraulically or electrically or may employ a combination of the two systems. Warning indicators are provided in the flight deck to show the pilot when the wheels are down and locked and when they are up and locked or if they are in intermediate positions. Systems for emergency operation are also provided. Due to the complexity of a retractable landing gear system, the pilot should adhere to specific operating procedures and should not exceed any operating limitations.

Landing Gear Systems

An electrical landing gear retraction system utilizes an electrically-driven motor for gear operation. The system is basically an electrically-driven jack for raising and lowering the gear. When a switch in the flight deck is moved to the UP position, the electric motor operates. Through a system of shafts, gears, adapters, an actuator screw, and a torque tube, a force is transmitted to the drag strut linkages. Thus, the gear retracts and locks. Struts are also activated that open and close the gear doors. If the switch is moved to the DOWN position, the motor reverses and the gear moves down and locks. Once activated, the gear motor continues to operate until an up or down limit switch on the motor's gearbox is tripped.

A hydraulic landing gear retraction system utilizes pressurized hydraulic fluid to actuate linkages to raise and lower the gear. When a switch in the flight deck is moved to the UP position, hydraulic fluid is directed into the gear up line. The fluid flows through sequenced valves and downlocks to the gear actuating cylinders. A similar process occurs during gear extension. The pump that pressurizes the fluid in the system can be either engine-driven or electrically-powered. If an electrically-powered pump is used to pressurize the fluid, the system is referred to as an electrohydraulic system. The system also incorporates a hydraulic reservoir to contain excess fluid and to provide a means of determining system fluid level.

Regardless of its power source, the hydraulic pump is designed to operate within a specific range. When a sensor detects excessive pressure, a relief valve within the pump opens, and hydraulic pressure is routed back to the reservoir. Another type of relief valve prevents excessive pressure that may result from thermal expansion. Hydraulic pressure is also regulated by limit switches. Each gear has two limit switches—one dedicated to extension and one dedicated to retraction. These switches de-energize the hydraulic pump after the landing gear has completed its gear cycle. In the event of limit switch failure, a backup pressure relief valve activates to relieve excess system pressure.

Controls and Position Indicators

Landing gear position is controlled by a switch on the flight deck panel. In most airplanes, the gear switch is shaped like a wheel in order to facilitate positive identification and to differentiate it from other flight deck controls.

Landing gear position indicators vary with different make and model airplanes. Some types of landing gear position indicators utilize a group of lights. One type consists of one green light to indicate when the landing gear is down and an amber light to indicate when the gear is up. [Figure 12-10] Another type consists of a group of three green lights, which illuminate when the landing gear is down and locked. [Figure 12-10] Still other systems incorporate a red or amber light to indicate when the gear is in transit or unsafe for landing. [Figure 12-11] When the lights use a "press to test" feature, the bulbs are often interchangeable. Integrated electronic displays may also indicate gear position on a portion of the screen without any dedicated lights.

Other types of landing gear position indicators consist of tab-type indicators with markings "UP" to indicate the gear is up and locked, a display of red and white diagonal stripes to show when the gear is unlocked, or a silhouette of each gear to indicate when it locks in the DOWN position.

Landing Gear Safety Devices

Most airplanes with a retractable landing gear have a gear warning horn that sounds when the airplane is configured for landing and the landing gear is not down and locked. Normally, the horn is linked to the throttle or flap position and/or the airspeed indicator so that when the airplane is below a certain airspeed, configuration, or power setting with the gear retracted, the warning horn sounds.

Accidental retraction of a landing gear may be prevented by such devices as mechanical downlocks, safety switches, and ground locks. Mechanical downlocks are built-in components of a gear retraction system and are operated automatically by the gear retraction system. To prevent accidental operation of the downlocks and inadvertent landing gear retraction while the airplane is on the ground, electrically-operated safety switches are installed.



Figure 12-10. Typical landing gear switch with combination amber and green. Another combination has a three light indicator.

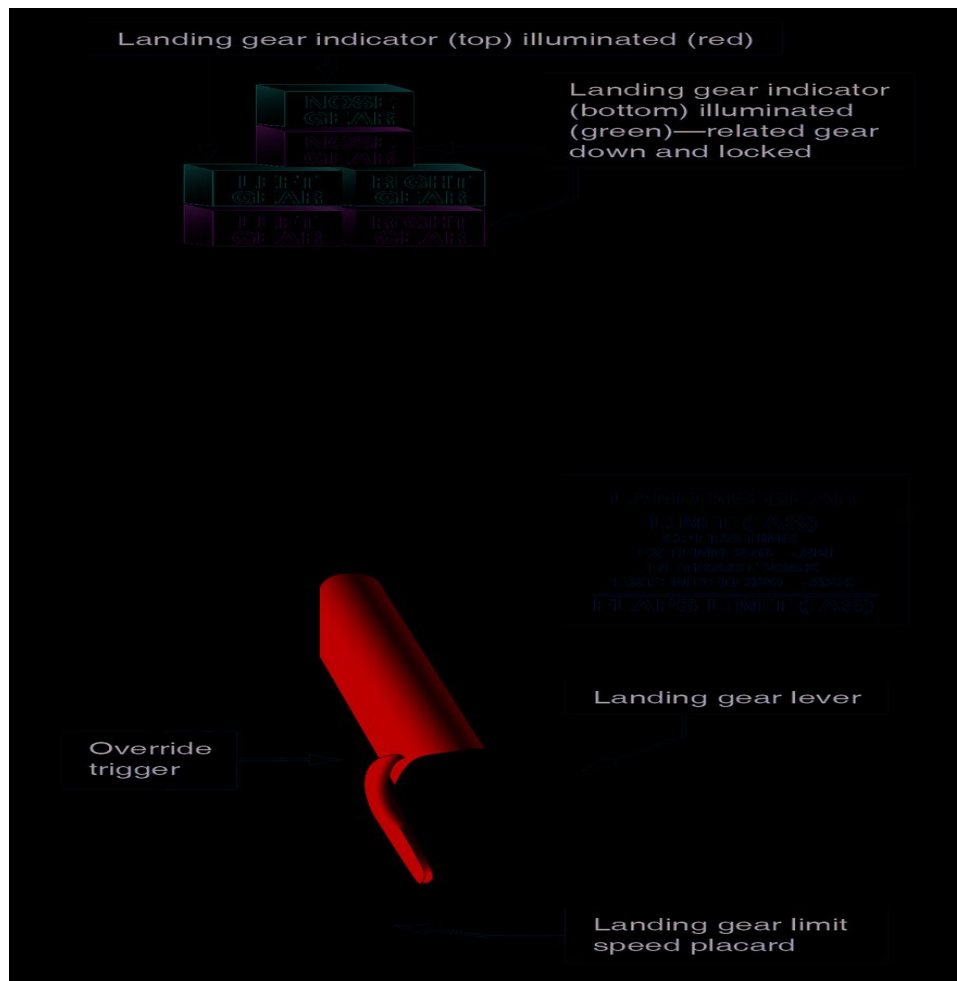


Figure 12-11. Landing gear handles and single and multiple light indicator.

A landing gear safety switch, sometimes referred to as a squat switch, is usually mounted in a bracket on one of the main gear shock struts. [Figure 12-12] When the strut is compressed by the weight of the airplane, the switch opens the electrical circuit to the motor or mechanism that powers retraction. In this way, if the landing gear switch in the flight deck is placed in the RETRACT position when weight is on the gear, the gear remains extended, and the warning horn may sound as an alert to the unsafe condition. Once the weight is off the gear, however, such as on takeoff, the safety switch releases and the gear retracts.

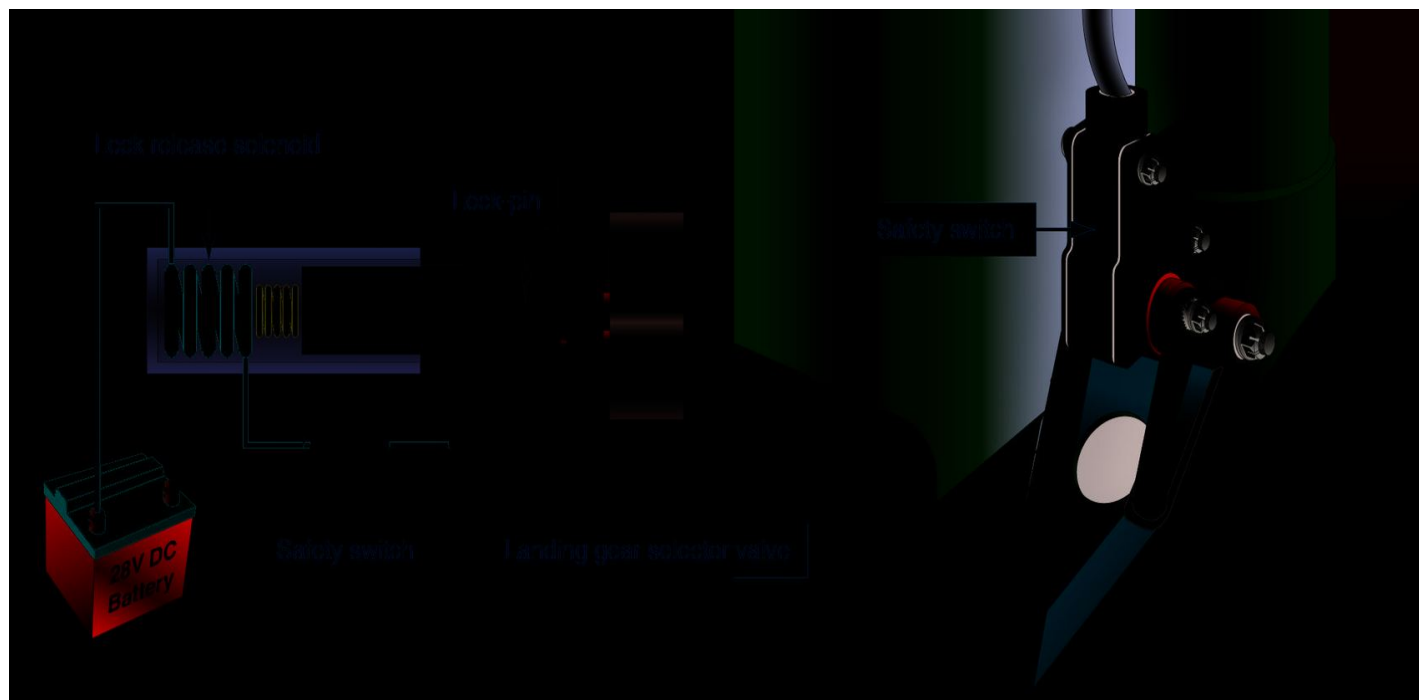


Figure 12-12. Landing gear safety switch.

Many airplanes are equipped with removable safety devices to prevent collapse of the gear when the airplane is on the ground. These devices are called ground locks. One common type is a pin installed in aligned holes drilled in two or more units of the landing gear support structure. Another type is a spring-loaded clip designed to fit around and hold two or more units of the support structure together. All types of ground locks usually have red streamers permanently attached to them to readily indicate whether or not they are installed.

Emergency Gear Extension Systems

The emergency gear extension system lowers the landing gear if the main power system fails. Some airplanes have an emergency release handle in the flight deck, which is connected through a mechanical linkage to the gear uplocks. When the handle is operated, it releases the uplocks and allows the gear to free fall or extend under their own weight. [Figure 12-13]

On other airplanes, release of the uplock is accomplished using compressed gas, which is directed to uplock release cylinders. In some airplanes, design configurations make emergency extension of the landing gear by gravity and air loads alone impossible or impractical. In these airplanes, provisions are included for forceful gear extension in an emergency. Some installations are designed so that either hydraulic fluid or compressed gas provides the necessary pressure, while others use a manual system, such as a hand crank for emergency gear extension. [Figure 12-14] Hydraulic pressure for emergency operation of the landing gear may be provided by an auxiliary hand pump, an accumulator, or an electrically-powered hydraulic pump depending on the design of the airplane.

Operational Procedures

Preflight

Because of their complexity, retractable landing gear demands a close inspection prior to every flight. The inspection should begin inside the flight deck. First, make certain that the landing gear selector switch is in the GEAR DOWN position. Then, turn on the battery master switch and ensure that the landing gear position indicators show that the gear is down and locked.